



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

PEOPLE set up a barricade in Minneapolis on Sunday amid the Trump administration’s immigration sweep.

‘We’re underage. We’re scared’

At Minneapolis school, half the students absent due to ICE fears

By ANDREA CASTILLO

MINNEAPOLIS — For weeks, administrators at this charter high school have arrived an hour before class, grabbed neon vests and walkie-talkies, and headed out into the cold to watch for ICE agents and escort students in.

Lately, fewer than half of the 800 students show up.

“Operation Metro Surge,” the immigration crackdown in Minnesota that led to nationwide protests after federal agents shot and killed

two U.S. citizens, has had students, parents and teachers on edge regardless of their immigration status.

Signs of a fearful new normal are all over the school. Green craft paper covers the bottom of many first-floor windows so outsiders can’t peer in. A notice taped outside one door says unauthorized entry is prohibited: “This includes all federal law enforcement personnel and activities unless authorized by lawful written direction from appropriate school officials or a valid court order.”

Staff coordinate throughout the day with a neighborhood watch group to determine whether ICE agents are nearby. When they are, classroom doors are locked and hallways emptied until staff announce “all clear.”

Similar tactics have been utilized by schools in other cities hit by immigration raids across the country. The Los Angeles Unified School District established a donation fund for affected families and created security perimeters around schools in the summer.

[See Minneapolis, A6]

DOJ’s loss of credibility seen in court defeats

Federal officials’ false narratives alleging assaults on agents fail to sway juries.

By JAMES QUEALLY AND BRITNY MEJIA

Just a few hours after Border Patrol agents shot and killed Alex Pretti in Minneapolis, the U.S. Department of Homeland Security issued a statement that said, without evidence, that the 37-year-old registered nurse “wanted to do maximum damage and massacre law enforcement.”

Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem would later imply Pretti had been “asked to show up and to continue to resist” by Minnesota’s governor.

Multiple videos from the scene immediately undercut those claims, and there has been no indication in the days since that Pretti threatened or planned to hurt law enforcement.

Several high-profile use-of-force incidents and arrests involving federal immigration agents have involved a similar cycle: strident statements by Trump administration officials, soon contradicted by video or other evidence. Some law enforcement experts believe the repeated falsehoods are harming federal authorities both in the public eye and in the courtroom.

The top federal prosecutor in Los Angeles, Bill Es-

sayli, has taken five defendants to trial on charges of assaulting officers — and his office has lost each case. Court records and a Times investigation show grand juries in Chicago, Washington, D.C., and Los Angeles have repeatedly rejected criminal filings from prosecutors in similar cases.

Despite the repeated judicial rebukes, administration officials have continued to push for criminal charges against people at protest scenes, including the controversial arrest of former CNN anchor Don Lemon on Friday.

“When top federal law enforcement leaders in the country push false narratives like this, it leads the public to question everything the government says going forward,” said Peter Carr, a former Justice Department spokesman in Washington who served in Democratic and Republican administrations. “You see that in how judges are reacting.” [See Credibility, A7]

5-year-old, father back in Minnesota

Freed from ICE lockup in Texas, Liam Conejo Ramos and his dad return home. **NATION, A4**

Anti-ICE protests erupt nationwide

Weekend events are held against federal immigration raids in L.A. and across U.S. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

No plan to expand state child-care subsidies

Budget proposal lacks funds for more spaces, stalling Newsom’s affordability aims.

By KATE SEQUEIRA

Jazmine Locke has filled out the paperwork and checked all the boxes. As a middle-income worker, she qualifies for California-subsidized day care for her 7-month-old daughter. Yet

she holds little hope she will ever make it off the waitlist. Her older son, now 12, never did.

“In my mind, I plan to pay for child care until she doesn’t need it anymore,” said Locke, who lives in Antelope Valley. “That’s not until high school, pretty much.”

Locke, like thousands of other families and providers, is confronting the effects of stalled progress in California’s child-care industry after Gov. Gavin Newsom’s proposed budget — with an

estimated \$3-billion deficit — did not fund his promised expansion of subsidized child care for the second straight year.

The proposal is a blow for low- and middle-income working parents who were hoping that affordable child care would be in their future. The demand is so high among eligible families that they remain on waitlists for years, and many children age out before they secure a spot.

Leaders in the child-care

industry are disappointed that Newsom, who has championed early childhood education, has not fulfilled his pledge.

“We are in a difficult budget situation right now, both within California, as well as so much uncertainty federally right now,” said Nina Buthee, executive director of EveryChild California. “But realizing that this is our child-care governor, there was a lot that was promised to the early care and education field, which I

feel is half-done.”

The median cost for full-time care for an infant in Los Angeles County is \$1,209 a month at a family child-care home and \$1,818 a month at a center in 2024, according to data from the California Budget & Policy Center.

For a preschooler, it costs \$1,121 at a home and \$1,271 at a center.

And for school-age children, care costs \$884 at a home and \$959 at a center.

“Thousands of families [See Child care, A8]

Altadena residents may face higher water bills

Struggling small utility plans a \$50 monthly ‘fire recovery fee.’

By IAN JAMES

When the Eaton fire raged through neighborhoods in Altadena, the flames leveled three-quarters of the homes served by the tiny Las Flores Water Co. It also destroyed the roofs of two covered reservoirs where the utility stored drinking water.

The company soon restored clean water to those homes left standing. But the disaster has left it with costly repairs, and a sharp drop in income because most of its 1,500 customers haven’t yet rebuilt or reconnected their water.

Attempting to avert financial failure, the private water company’s board now plans to start charging people a new “fire recovery fee” of about \$3,000 over the next five years, or about \$50 a month.

It’s the best way to avoid insolvency, said John Bednarski, president of the Las Flores board. Its reserves, now roughly \$500,000, are shrinking.

“It’s a stopgap,” Bednarski said. “We need an infusion of sustainable funds to keep the company solvent.”

The Eaton fire in January 2025 destroyed more than 6,000 homes and over 3,000 other structures.

Las Flores Water Co. is the smallest of three private water utilities in Altadena. All are grappling with budget problems after the fire and adopting plans to charge more.

Of the three, Las Flores faces the most severe cash-flow shortfall. The increase in water bills is expected to [See Water, A9]

Governor’s race is wide open and awaits a star to emerge

By SEEMA MEHTA

In a state that’s home to nearly 40 million people and the fourth-largest economy in the world, the race for California governor has been lost in the shadow of President Trump’s combustible return to office and, thus far, the absence of a candidate charismatic enough to break out of the pack.

For the first time in recent history, there is no clear front-runner with less than

five months before the June primary election.

“This is the most wide-open governor’s race we’ve seen in California in more than a quarter of a century,” said Dan Schnur, a political communications professor who teaches at USC, Pepperdine and UC Berkeley. “We’ve never seen a multicandidate field with so little clarity and such an absence of anything even resembling a front-runner.”

“There’s no precedent in the modern political era for a

campaign that’s this crowded,” Schnur said.

Opinion polls bear this out, with more voters saying they are undecided or coalescing behind any of the dozen prominent candidates who have announced bids.

Former Rep. Katie Porter (D-Irvine) led the field with the support of 21% of respondents in a survey of likely voters by the Public Policy Institute of California released in December. For-

[See Governor, A8]



NIC COURY Associated Press

ROUGHLY 12,260 monarch butterflies were recorded wintering in the West, the third-lowest since 1997.

Plunging monarch butterfly tallies may be ‘new normal’

By MEG TANAKA

The number of western monarch butterflies overwintering along the California coast continues to remain near historic lows, according to a new annual count, adding to growing concern that the population’s long decline may be becoming the norm.

Roughly 12,260 monarch butterflies were recorded across 249 overwintering sites during surveys conducted from late November through early December, according to the 29th annual Western Monarch Count released Wednesday by the

Xerces Society, a nonprofit environmental organization. The count relies on hundreds of trained volunteers and partner organizations to tally monarchs as they cluster in coastal tree groves.

The total is the third-lowest tally since the count began in 1997, after the 9,119 monarchs recorded in 2024 and the record low of 1,901 in 2020. According to a Xerces Society news release accompanying the new data, western monarch populations regularly numbered in the low millions in the 1980s.

Although monarch popu- [See Monarchs, A9]

Texas upset buoys Democrats’ hopes

Their candidate wins state Senate seat by 14 points in district Trump won by 17. **NATION, A4**

Leaving her mark on film and TV

If Catherine O’Hara was on board, it was surely a win. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 76/52. **B6**

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CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

GRAMMY AWARDS

Bad Bunny arrives at Crypto.com Arena. His nominations included album, song and record of the year. Scan this code to read our coverage at latimes.com.